



**man. She now holds the cards to the future of Pakistan.**

that began changing first with the massive reception accorded to her in Karachi. The welcome may have been cleverly stage-managed by PPP—with thousands of supporters from all over the country having been paid to attend it—but it was also clever optics, showcasing that Bhutto could still attract a large, dedicated following. Such a show of strength is particularly useful in Punjab, where votes are often swayed by perceptions about future power. Even the bomb attack on her procession, which killed over 150, strengthened her politically by casting her as a “brave fighter” against rising extremism.

But there were still rumblings within the anti-Musharraf opposition that Bhutto’s nominal statements against the General were “scripted” and “superficial”, and that she was simply angling to get a better deal. Even after the imposition of martial law on November 3—or “Emergency” in Government parlance—most analysts read her statements as cautious rather than confrontational. Such distrust seems to have disappeared with Bhutto’s statement that she can “no longer envision negotiations with General Musharraf”. She has reached out to other Opposition leaders, particularly Sharif, currently exiled in Saudi Arabia, Jamaat-e-Islami’s



**CHINK IN THE ARMOUR:** Bhutto’s efforts to unite the Opposition spell trouble for the General

her in international courts with much vigour. Some of these, pertaining to fraud and money laundering in Switzerland and Spain, were nearing conclusion. A conviction in any of them might have spelt the end of Bhutto’s political career.

Then came Musharraf’s proclamation of the National Reconciliation Ordinance (NRO), which granted amnesty to all political leaders and bureaucrats during Pakistan’s “democratic interregnum” between 1988 and 1999. Most saw it as a blatant sop to Bhutto, since it wiped out the cases against her within Pakistan and undermined the proceedings in the Swiss and Spanish courts. The kid-gloves with which Bhutto was treated, and her party’s refusal to resign from the assemblies during the presidential elections in October—as the remaining Opposition did—added weight to the view that an understanding for power-sharing had been reached. All of

Qazi Hussain Ahmed and cricketer-turned-politician Imran Khan, to unite them under the “one-point agenda” of restoring the Constitution. Hints have been dropped that the entire Opposition may boycott the polls, rendering them meaningless. Bhutto’s political credibility has suddenly gone up. So what factors have brought this about? And where does she go from here?

“Our negotiations with General Musharraf were aimed at smoothing the path towards democracy, avoiding instability and bloodshed,” says PPP spokesperson Sherry Rehman, who is under house arrest with Bhutto in Lahore. “But after the beating up and the arrests of peaceful citizens, the suspension of civil liberties and the curbs on independent media, there is no point in talking to him, now that he has obviously decided to go in a different direction, away from